

Open-Source Project Hack-a-thon

Build on a real project, with a real CIS student team, for the fun of it.

Foreword

This started as a simple idea: to find and work on an open-source project for course work credit. When the idea was presented to the class in Spring 2026, they decided they wanted to start our own CIS open-source project that would cross courses and semesters to be a living legacy of what CIS students could accomplish as a team. They chose an open-source video game, and began putting the first pieces of it in place, and said, “how about we have a hack-a-thon to build it.” This semester we extend the project with another hack-a-thon.

This document exists to give that effort a little structure so it can keep going and so everyone can take part. That is all it is. It is not meant to turn a good thing into paperwork.

The spirit of the whole thing is simple: it is a real project, it is yours, and the point is to build, cooperate, and enjoy being part of something larger than a single assignment. You are not graded on how impressive the result. You are asked to show up, take part in good faith, and contribute to the effort. If you do that, you have met it.

1. What This Is

The project is an open-source video game that students started last semester and are continuing to build. It is genuinely ongoing, which means your work can become part of something that outlives this course. Two of your fellow students serve as project managers and help coordinate the effort.

Justin Dysarz – Manager

Brady Benoit – Assistant Manager

There are two graded parts to the Hack-a-thon:

- **Task W3: The Planning Meeting:** A single meeting of everyone involved, held during Week 3, where the team gets organized and decides how the event will run.
- **Task W13: The Hack-a-thon:** The event itself, held the weekend of November 9, where the team works together to move the project forward.

Everything else in this document supports those two tasks or offers you an optional way to get more involved.

2. Task W3: The Planning Meeting

Points: 20. Held during Week 3 (may run slightly later if the team needs it, but no later than Week 5 so everyone has time to plan for the November event).

The meeting is where the team gets on the same page. In-person students should attend in-person; online students can attend online. However, it is possible to for anyone to attend online if circumstances require that flexibility.

Before the meeting

- **Join the Discord server:** (<https://discord.gg/CqBqZx2Dcp>) You will do this as part of the

Orientation assignment. Once you are in, post a very short introduction in the introductions channel and set your server nickname to your real name (at least your first name), so we can identify you by name rather than a handle.

- **Help pick the time:** The team decides when the meeting happens. Aim for Week 3. It needs to happen before Week 5 so everyone can make plans to attend the hack-a-thon.

At the meeting

Cover at least these:

- **The project managers:** Confirm who they are and what they will coordinate.
- **Where the project stands:** A quick tour of the current state of the game so everyone knows the starting point.
- **Where the team wants to take it:** The directions people are interested in developing.
- **The plan for the Hack-a-thon weekend:** Decide the logistics for November 9 (see below).

Deciding the Hack-a-thon logistics

This is the team's call, not mine. The event takes place over the weekend of November 9, and the available window runs from Friday at noon through Sunday evening. You do not have to use all of it. The team can run the whole weekend, a single day, an evening, or whatever shape works.

Work out the following:

- How to handle in-person and online participants together, so both can take part in the live discussion.
- Roughly how much time participants are expected to be present, keeping it reasonable.
- Any other logistics the team can think of. Keep it simple.

I will provide dinner for those attending the hack-a-thon in-person.

The Hack-a-thon is held in-person and on Discord at the same time. In-person students are expected to take part in person; your CIS peers want you to be there with them. If you have a genuine reason you cannot, talk to me first and we will work it out.

After the meeting

Post in Discord what you would like to contribute to the project. This is not a binding commitment. As the semester goes on you can work on the project if you want, and you can change your mind about what you want to do. The idea is simply to stake out a starting interest.

3. Getting Involved During the Semester (Optional)

Between the planning meeting and the event, you are welcome to work on the project, talk about it in Discord, and contribute as much or as little as you like. None of this is required. It is here because the project is real and some of you will want to be part of it before November. If that is you, jump in.

The Contribution Bonus

Real contribution to the project is worth recognizing on its own. If you contribute to the project outside of the Hack-a-thon weekend itself, meaning during the regular semester, you can earn

bonus points added directly to your Task total score. This does not replace any other assignment. Every other Task and Lab is still fully required, for everyone.

- **Up to 20 bonus points:** Added to your Task score for real, verified contributions made outside the hackathon weekend. Twenty points is the cap for the semester, not per contribution.
- **The contribution has to be real and visible:** It must be actual work that lives in the project, a change that is now part of the game, a problem solved, a feature added, not a description of work you intend to do. If it is not in the project, it does not count.
- **The managers assess it:** The two project managers review what you contributed and recommend its level of significance. I make the final decision on how many points, if any, get added. This is a subjective decision and you must abide by the decision.
- **The window runs through the end of Week 15:** Contributions can be brought forward any time during the semester, up through the end of Week 15.

A note on Week 15 and the holiday. Week 15 is Thanksgiving week. Nothing about this project is expected or required over the holiday. The window simply remains open through that week as a courtesy for anyone who, on their own, wants to keep working.

How a contribution gets verified

The two project managers review the contributions. They are peer-reviewing your work: they confirm that it is genuinely yours, that it is real, and they recommend its level of significance to the project. I review their opinion, the contribution, and make the point decision. The managers witness and advise; the grade decision is mine and I will not share the decision with them.

You record a contribution using the Contribution Bonus Record (a short, separate form). One record per contribution.

4. Task W13: The Hack-a-thon

Points: 80, plus up to 20 bonus points. The weekend of November 9. The bonus points come from contributions made outside the hackathon weekend, described above.

This is the main event, and the idea behind it is deliberately simple: work as a team to move the project forward, and enjoy it. There are no strict requirements, no deliverables to hit, and no report to agonize over. Discuss, build, learn, and cooperate without worrying about whether you are “doing enough.”

You do not need to be present for every hour of the weekend. You are expected to be part of the live effort: there for the discussions, contributing to the work, present with your team, whether in the lab or on Discord. As long as the team and I can see that you took part in good faith, you have met it.

How the points are earned

Take part in good faith and you have met it. If you show up, work with your team, and contribute to the effort, you have earned the points. This is not scored on how much you produce or how polished it is.

After the event you will fill out a short form (the Hack-a-thon Contribution Form) noting what you worked on and who you worked with. It takes a few minutes and is not graded on length or writing. Its only job is to record that you took part, so the points are documented. The real

evidence is your participation, which the managers and I see directly during the event.

If you cannot attend

If you have a genuine conflict with the November 9 weekend, talk to me first, before the event, and we will find a reasonable way for you to take part. This needs to be discussed early, not at the last moment.

This is meant to be fun and it is meant to be real. Take it in that spirit, take part in good faith, and it will be one of the great things you do this term.

5. Quick Reference

Table 1. *Hack-a-thon at a glance*

Item	Detail
Task W3: Meeting	Week 3. Get organized, confirm managers, plan the event.
Task W13: Event	Weekend of November 9, in the lab and on Discord.
Discord	Join, introduce yourself, set your nickname to your real name.
Contribution bonus	Optional. Earn up to 20 bonus points on Tasks for real, manager-verified contributions made outside the hackathon weekend. Window runs through end of Week 15.
Attendance issue	Talk to me before the event and we will work it out.
The form	Short, ungraded, a record that you took part.